

Airport Hacks

Cheat Sheet — From Check-In to Gate in Record Time

THE PERFECT AIRPORT TIMELINE

- T-48h** Online check-in opens. Pick seats immediately.
- T-24h** Reconfirm flight. Download boarding pass offline.
- T-3h** Domestic flight minimum. International: T-3h.
- T-2h** Clear security. Head straight to gate first.
- T-45m** Final boarding call window. Be at gate.
- T-20m** Gates close. No exceptions.

SECURITY LINE SPEED HACKS

- ♦ Wear slip-on shoes — save 2 min per trip
- ♦ Jacket, belt, coins in bag BEFORE the queue
- ♦ Laptop in dedicated top-pocket — out in seconds
- ♦ Liquids bag visible at top of backpack
- ♦ TSA PreCheck / EU equivalent = separate lane
- ♦ Trusted Traveler status: up to 15 min saved

LOUNGE ACCESS — WITHOUT BUSINESS CLASS

- Priority Pass Card** Amex Platinum, Curve Metal: free Priority Pass
- LoungeBuddy App** Day passes from €25-40. Worth it for long layovers.
- DragonPass** Standalone app: book individual visits
- Credit Card Perks** Check your card's travel benefits — many include 2 visits/yr

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Delays, Upgrades & Hidden Tricks

FLIGHT DELAY RIGHTS

1

EU261 Rule

EU flights: delays 3h+ = €250–600 compensation per person.

2

AirHelp App

Submit claim automatically. Works worldwide.

3

Meal Vouchers

Ask at gate immediately after delay announced.

4

Overnight Delay

Airline must provide hotel + transfers for 5h+ delays.

UPGRADE SECRETS

5

Dress Smart

Looking the part at check-in increases upgrade chances 3×.

6

Ask Nicely

"Is there any availability in business today?" — costs nothing.

7

Check-In Last

Overbooked flights: last check-in often bumped to business.

8

Bid Upgrade Tool

Many airlines offer bid upgrades 48h before: Lufthansa, BA, KLM.

LAYOVER PLAYBOOK

2h layover

Stay airside. Gate first, then food.

4h layover

Lounge + power nap. Skip airport food prices.

6h+ layover

Consider visa-free city visit (many airports allow it).